



Prince in Paris

Shortly before his overthrow, Norodom Sihanouk addresses the media outside the Elysée Palace, Paris, after a meeting with French President Pompidou. Sihanouk argued for a halt to US involvement in Cambodia. A few days later, he visited Moscow and Beijing.

Operation Menu

The Nixon administration was intent upon one thing, defeating North Vietnam and the Viet Cong, and had little regard for Cambodia. In journalist William Shawcross's phrase, Cambodia was only a "side show." On March 18, 1969, the US Air Force had begun Operation Menu, a covert bombing campaign of eastern Cambodia, known to be a support area for the infiltration of North Vietnamese forces into South Vietnam. American commanders also thought it was the location of the headquarters of the Central Office for South Vietnam (COSVN), the base of operations for communist forces in the South. The nature of so-called sanctuaries and of COSVN itself had been in dispute—one reason Johnson had refused to bomb Cambodia—but Nixon and many of his military advisers were committed to this strategy. General Abrams promised that a single B-52 sortie would destroy COSVN. In the event, almost 4,000 sorties were flown, but COSVN, a main target, was not destroyed.

Effects of the bombing

Many Cambodian villagers died in these raids, however. The Vietnamese communist forces moved westward from the border and further into Cambodia, increasing their political influence on the Cambodian population. The United States had never asked Sihanouk for approval of these bombing operations.

In addition to the devastating impact of the American bombing and continued ground operations on the Cambodian population as a whole, US strategy also had a catastrophic effect on Sihanouk's hold on power.